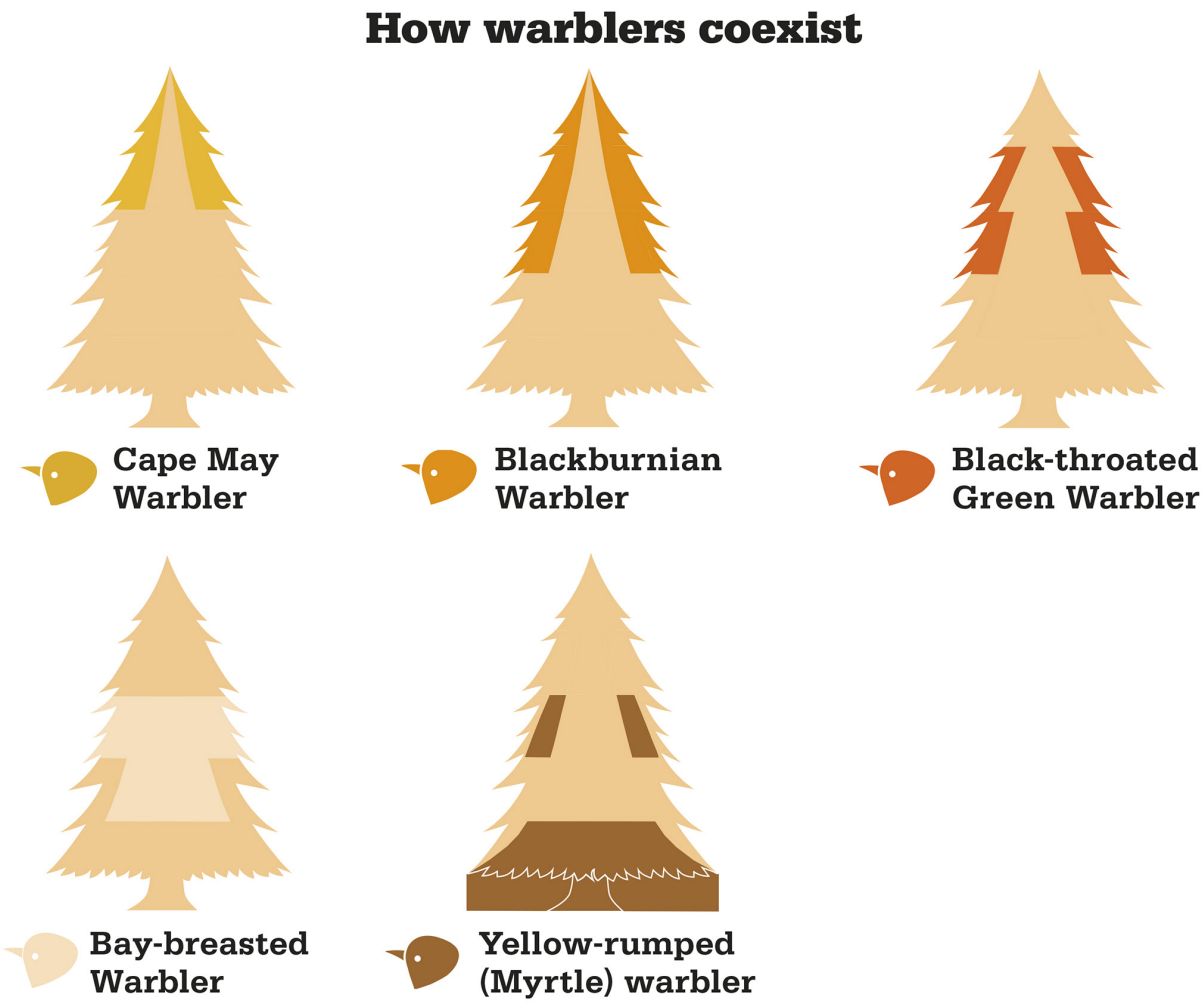


Five species of warblers are able to share the same tree, because each inhabits its own “niche.” Living in this way, without much overlap, the birds do not compete.

An invasive competitor

Problems often arise if an exotic species is suddenly introduced to an ecosystem. Britain’s red and gray squirrels provide a clear example. When the gray arrived from America in the 1870s, both squirrel species competed for the same food and habitat, which put the native red squirrel populations under pressure. The gray had the edge because it can adapt its diet; it is able, for instance, to eat green acorns, while the red can only digest mature acorns. Within the same area of forest, gray squirrels can decimate the food